Topic 1: Introduction to Organizational Communication
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1.3 Common Types of Organizational Communication

Communication can take many shapes within an organization, and all organizations require a different approach to effectively reach their intended audiences.

Types of Communication

Internal and Client-Facing (External) Communication

Internal communication refers to all the types of communication that go on within an organization. No matter your role in an organization, you will take part in internal communication every day. Internal communication can include the following:

1. Organization mission statement and values
2. Training and development programs
3. Projects and change management initiatives
4. Memos
5. Organizational safety regulations and handbooks
6. Communication between employees

The counterpart to internal communication, **client-facing communication**, pertains to all types of communication created by an organization with an audience outside the organization. Types of client-facing communication include the following:

1. Marketing materials such as advertisements
2. Emails
3. Website and blog content
4. Public statements
5. Product descriptions
6. Packaging materials
7. Conference presentations

In this course, we will mainly be focusing on internal communication and the best methods for fostering communication between employees.

Formal and Informal Communication

Formal communication is likely what first comes to mind when you hear the term *organizational communication*. **Formal communication** includes the transmission of information such as the policies and procedures of an organization, company goals, presentations, and organization-wide emails or announcements. It is usually written or recorded and is more likely to come from the top of the organization and distributed down toward employees, though this is not always the case.

At first, informal communication may not seem as crucial as formal communication. However, it is probably the most common type of communication that occurs within an organization and includes conversations between employees about projects, addressing problems, and sometimes discussing matters unrelated to the specific jobs. However, if managers and employees are not properly trained in informal communication, it can cause contention and disconnect, which often leads to communication failure on important subjects.

Horizontal and Vertical Communication

Horizontal and vertical communication refer to whether the communication takes place on the same or different levels of the organizational structure. **Vertical communication** occurs between different levels in an organization's hierarchy, often from superior to subordinate, while **horizontal communication** occurs between peers who generally hold the same rank or status within an organization.

Vertical communication is often more formal and would include an official memo from a CEO or policy changes from executives that are passed down to employees. Vertical communication can also occur from subordinate to superior in the form of an employee satisfaction survey or an employee bringing up a problem to a supervisor. Horizontal communication is often more informal and includes teams working on a project together or a meeting between managers.

Horizonal Communication

- Less formal
- Often oral
- Usually two-way

Vertical Communication

- More formal
- Written
- Often one-way and does not invite a response

Communication Channels

A **communication channel** is the way communications are transferred to reach their intended recipients. Some channels through which you probably receive information on a regular basis include television, radio, email, social media, and face-to-face communication. The communication channel is often just as important as the communication itself. Organizations should make sure that important information is able to reach employees in a fast, efficient, and convenient manner. If an important new organizational initiative is buried in a newsletter that nobody reads, it will not be effective no matter how well written and motivating it is.

Some internal communication channels include the following:

- Emails
- An internal blog
- Organizational newsletters
- Video conferences
- Private messaging
- Project management software
- Intranet software
- Physical signs and posters
- Face-to-face communication

Each of these channels has its advantages and disadvantages, and organizations will use a variety of channels for different forms of communication. Below is a table of best practices to consider when using each communication channel within an organization:

Table 1.1
Communication Channels

Communication Channel	Use it for…	Pros	Cons
Email	• Documenting formal policy changes • Exchanging information easily • Giving status updates on projects	• Easy to use • Provides documentation • You're able to proofread the message before sending	• Difficult to capture tone and other emotional cues • An employee's inbox can quickly become overfilled
Internal Blog	• Distributing stories within an organization • Sharing knowledge • Highlighting what other teams are doing	• Creates connection between departments • Increases discussion and idea exchange in highly matrixed organizations	• Difficult to get workers to see and read the blogs • Posts can contain too much corporate jargon
Organizational Newsletters	• Updating employees on company policies, news, social events, services, and other activities • Creating connection between company resources and content across multiple channels	• Easy to point to other communication channels • Engages employees on a regular and consistent basis (whether the newsletter is weekly, monthly or quarterly) • Ability to track open rates, clicks, and other essential data	• Difficult to get workers to see and read the newsletter • It may get boring and repetitive over time • It can become too long and include too many bold headlines and information
Video Conferencing	• Communicating with a group of people in various locations • Relaying a message to a large group • If a 1:1 is needed with an employee	• You're able to read body language • Creates connection even when you're not located in the same place • Everyone gets the message at the same time	• Booking and scheduling (especially across time zones) can become tedious • Technology issues or malfunctions can occur
Private Messaging	• Urgent questions • Informal talks • Real-time conversations where you need a quick reply or feedback	• Perfect for getting quick responses • You can add some personality and emotional cues through emoji features	• Operates in real time and can feel interruptive for the recipient • Depending on service used, no record of chat
Project Management Software	• Separate teams that need to keep track of project road maps, deadlines, and other important information • Defining inputs and outputs that are to be achieved on a project	• Clarity on project timetables • A centralized place where communication on a specific project is hosted • Perfect for sending messages specific to a team or project	• Depending on the software, it can be hard to share documents and other important communication messages
Intranet Software	• Creating a virtual hub and meeting place for employees • Showcasing stories, blogs, and other important company news in a central, virtual directory	• Streamlines communication across an organization • Establishes an internal network for sharing the "social" moments of a company, boosting morale • Encourages knowledge sharing	• Costly to implement at first • Can decrease employee productivity overtime • Messages can get lost amongst the intranet "clutter"
Physical Signs and Posters	• Displaying information that does not change over time (such as an organization's mission, values, vision, etc.) • Highlighting a message for a specific period	• Physical reminders keep the poster or sign's topic top of mind • Identifies seasonal or time bound messages that should be at the forefront of a worker's thoughts • Visual cues can add depth to the message	• They can quickly become outdated • Costly to produce at scale • Difficult to identify a central location where they will get viewed the most
Face-to-Face Communication	• Issues can be discussed and resolved in real time • Exchanging information and messages on sensitive issues • Convincing someone	• You're able to interpret and see body language and facial expressions • Building connection is easier • Troubleshooting and collaborating in real time can lead to more trust	• Leaves no record of the communication • Can be difficult to find the time • Can become tedious and ineffective in larger meetings

Each communication channel has its uses, and you should consider which is best for the specific item you are trying to communicate. For instance, Shell's implementation of Microsoft Office 365 in 2018 to create a more personalized, collaborative experience across its 84,000-employee workforce relied on multiple communication channels to drive the change. To update how its global workforce communicated, it introduced Yammer, a new intranet; Microsoft Stream, which became the company's enterprise video service; and SharePoint, a content library and publishing tool.

As Cindy Vosselman, internal communications advisor at Shell, described it, "Internal communications are crucial for supporting the delivery of Shell business goals, priorities, and strategies. The more our communication engages our workforce, the more successful we will be as a company."[1] And she was right. In updating Shell's digital communication channels, Shell sought to make itself more agile, integrated, and personal. For example, when the incoming chief executive officer, Ben van Beurden, was being introduced to his employees, Shell did it through Table Talk, an informal video chat program they launched. The program allowed everyone to receive the same message while allowing everyone to also ask questions in real time. It was an overwhelming success.

Shell's digital transformation and update of its communication channels relied on getting the message across multiple avenues to its workforce. Employees were equally thrilled that Yammer, the company's intranet, had channels they could access to engage and connect with upper management and each other. By using the communication channels in a fun and engaging way, Shell connected its global workforce using their digital technology. As you work through the subsequent topics in this resource, keep this in mind: the channels you have available to you in an organization can determine how, and in what way, the intended receipt hears your message. And this can be all the difference in the projects you are spearheading within the organization.

References

Microsoft. (2018, September 24). Employee engagement soars as Shell energizes internal communication with Office 365. Microsoft Customer Stories. https://customers.microsoft.com/en-us/story/royal-dutch-shell-mining-oil-gas-office365

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